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Studying New Literacies

Michele Knobel & Colin Lankshear

The Idea of “New Literacies”

The idea of new literacies has been developed since the early 1990s (Buckingham, 1993) with the aim of helping us understand and respond to some of the deep changes evident during recent decades that have had an impact on education. Specifically, the idea of “new literacies” focuses on ways in which meaning-making practices are *evolving* under contemporary conditions that include, but are in no way limited to, technological changes associated with the rise and proliferation of digital electronics. New literacies researchers and scholars seek to explore and understand continuities and differences between the ways people in societies like our own produced, distributed, shared, and negotiated meanings during an era that entered transition from the 1950s, and the ways people have increasingly produced, distributed, shared, and negotiated meanings from, say, the 1980s. Furthermore, those who investigate new literacies try to anticipate beyond the present and envisage how best to educate *now* in order to enhance learners’ capacities for effective meaning-making and communication in the foreseeable future. Integral to this is the close study of empirical cases of distinctively contemporary

social practices of doing communicative and meaning “work” by means of creating tangible public artifacts that people make, exchange, and contest meanings around.

While variations exist in how educationists understand “new literacies” (Lankshear & Knobel, 2013), a considerable corpus of research and scholarship has emerged during the past 15 years undertaken from a sociocultural-New Literacies Studies perspective. This work focuses on skills, knowledge, and tools *in use* within social practices where participants are undertaking tasks and pursuing purposes in a range of everyday settings—particularly in the world beyond school, since it is the world beyond school with which education is ultimately concerned. It aims to provide richly detailed examples and consider what these indicate in terms of trends and shifts in literacy practices and, in many cases, to suggest how learning and instruction might usefully be informed by these changing practices.

From a conceptual and theoretical perspective we identify *paradigm* cases of new literacies as differing from conventional literacies on two dimensions: technically/technologically, and in terms of what we call a different “ethos” (Lankshear & Knobel, 2011, Ch. 3). Along with others (e.g., Street, 1998), we also recognize instances of new literacies that do not presuppose use of digital technologies and media. “Peripheral” cases of new literacies, such as paper-based and face-to-face creation, distribution, and sharing of, say, fan fiction (Jenkins, 2010) or zines (Guzzetti & Gamboa, 2004), emphasize the new ethos of participatory culture (Jenkins, 2010, p. 236). Our interest here is in paradigm cases only.



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As social practices mediated by digital technologies, new literacies differ fundamentally from conventional print literacies on the basis that their inscriptions are rendered in pixels on screens rather than by impressions on paper, by means of digital code rather than material analogue means (whether printed and illustrated/imagined/diagrammed by hand, typewriter, or press). That is, new literacies involve a shift from material inscription to digital coding, from analogue to digital representations. Consequently, “new” kinds of texts are seamlessly multimodal rather than involving distinct processes for different modes (text, image, sound). You basically click for everything, since beneath the clicks lies the digital code that renders multiple modes. With the right kind of knowledge someone who cannot draw a straight line or play a note on a conventional instrument can create an impressive image and compose a significant piece of music (although conventional artistic and musical knowledge remain powerful assets). In addition, the development of electronic networks vastly extends the reach and “real time” immediacy of new literacies beyond anything remotely possible under print. Meaningful expression and cultural artifacts can be shared with the click of a mouse and as extensively as one chooses via digital networks.

As social practices characterized by a new “ethos,” new literacies are more participatory, collaborative, and distributed, and less “published,” less “author-centric,” and less “individual” than conventional literacies. Typically, although—regretfully—not universally (Gee & Hayes, 2013), engaging in social media sites, (passionate) affinity spaces (Gee, 2013), and within environments and practices of participatory cultures (Jenkins et al., 2006) involves deep interactivity, openness to feedback, sharing of resources and expertise, and a will to collaborate and provide support that is writ large into myriad contemporary everyday practices. Participants in new literacy practices actively seek out memberships and peers in areas of affinity and interest, and pursue different kinds of relationships between “authors” and “audiences” from those characterizing

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many conventional literacy practices. They generally value attending to the interests and knowledge of others, recognize that quality is judged by groups rather than appointed experts, welcome diversity of opinion in decision-making, and so on. This broad “ethos” of new literacies sets them apart from simply being conventional literacies in digital form.

As such, paradigm cases of new literacies include such practices as creating fan fiction, blogging and microblogging, remixing cultural artifacts, photo curating and sharing, video gaming, video game modding, online social networking, editing wikis, creating machinima, editing anime music videos, sharing and contributing to memes, building apps, creating animations, and participating in interest-driven online forums, to name just a smattering.

A practice orientation to new literacies examines new literacies in terms of technology, knowledge, and skills—where skills are understood as “co-ordinated sets of actions,” and practices as “socially developed and patterned ways of using technology and knowledge to accomplish tasks [that are] directed to [realizing] socially recognized goals [or purposes]” (Scribner & Cole, 1981, p. 236). As practices, literacies—all literacies, “new” or conventional—involve bringing technology, knowledge, and skills together within contexts of social purpose.

Jen Scott Curwood’s study of now-16-years-old Cassie, a moderator for a very popular fansite devoted to *The Hunger Games* trilogy, provides a typical example of studying new literacies as social practices (Curwood, 2013; Curwood, Magnifico, & Lammers, 2013). Cassie is an active contributor to the site. She writes and posts news stories, book reviews, items about fan art and other works, and posts to the site’s Twitter feed. Curwood documents how Cassie’s literacies are tied to a particular purpose—sharing with others a deep interest in and enjoyment of *The Hunger Games*—and how Cassie makes use of a range of skills, and techniques in doing so (e.g., updating site posts regularly, using Twitter hashtags effectively). Cassie also makes good use of her extensive *Hunger Games* knowledge and explicitly aims to “deepen [fans’] understanding of the trilogy through her blog posts, quiz questions, and tweets” (Curwood, Magnifico, & Lammers, 2013, p. 21). Curwood’s account shows how Cassie engages in widely valued writing practices that often surpass what’s expected of young people in many classrooms (e.g., to write one fiction, Cassie closely analyzed 10 novels; used textual evidence to create a character backstory; wrote for a very real and well-informed audience). Cassie’s literacies are very

much tied to “being a fan” and fan practices associated with *The Hunger Games*.

Curwood’s study, among many others, typifies the corpus of new literacies research and scholarship under consideration here. Based on our survey of many such examples (for a typical selection, see Lankshear & Knobel, 2013), we offer in the following section a sample of the kinds of things we believe educators can learn from this body of work.

What Have We Learned From New Literacies Research?

New literacies research that focuses on young people “doing their thing” in a range of social contexts has generated a rich store of insights into how young people learn and engage with literacies, many of which contrast markedly with how they learn and “do” literacy in schools. The following is a list of key findings from this set of studies we feel are worth teachers’ consideration. These aren’t the only findings we could have listed, and neither are they prioritized, but we feel they might usefully and concretely inform instructional decision-making. Sample references for further reading are also included, but these are far from exhaustive.

- Not everyone has to know or be good at exactly the same thing; often outcomes are richer when young people bring different bits and pieces of knowledge and know-how to collaborative efforts (Gee & Hayes, 2013). Schools, however, tend to insist on everyone knowing exactly the same thing in the same way.
- Producing work for a targeted, informed audience directly shapes linguistic, design, and creative decisions, and young people are able to talk about these quite explicitly (Curwood, 2013). Schools typically require students to write for hypothetical, generic audiences.
- Ongoing cycles of feedback, mentoring, and support from others—novices and experts alike—who share the same interest or goals play a crucial role in learning and practicing new literacies (Black, 2008). Schools usually privilege teacher feedback over peer feedback on work-in-progress; assessment tends to be summative and focus on technical details, with little in-process advice or mentoring regarding production within a particular specialized space or domain.

- Literacies are part and parcel of social practices and understanding the practice from the *inside* as a full, participating member matters (Burn, 2008; Jenkins et al., 2006). Schools tend to treat literacy as an autonomous system.
- Doing, contributing, making, and sharing are significant activities (Alvermann, 2010; Ito et al., 2010). Schools approach knowledge in terms of consuming information and practicing teacher-taught strategies, often driven by packaged curriculum and textbooks, rather than in terms of production by insiders to a field and novices learning to become insiders.
- Young people “pull” on available resources—content, materials, people—right at the point of need as they are working on something (Leander & Mills, 2007). This just-in-time approach to learning contrasts with schools and their tendency to “push” a broad range of content at students for abstract, “just-in-case” purposes (Hagel & Brown, 2005).
- Remixing cultural items to produce new works is valued and central to cultural development within societies (Lankshear & Knobel, 2011). This challenges schools’ assumptions about the importance of individualized authorship and the production of “original” works.
- Distributed effort and the ability to communicate with others across distance, cultures, and languages matters (Curwood, Magnifico, & Lammers, 2013; Lam, 2009). Practical experiences entailing such things are less than common in schools.
- Participation in new literacy practices like video games (in particular, but also others) engages good learning principles such as creating and honoring preparation for future learning, building in real choices, creating motivation for extended engagement, banishing anything “remedial,” providing opportunities to take control of one’s own learning, teaching skill sets in relation to practices, and strategies for accomplishing goals and carrying out actions, to name just five. These are largely absent in schools (Gee, 2013).
- Specialist language uses are entailed in most new literacies practices (Gee & Hayes, 2013). “Premium” grade digital literacies (Gee, 2013, Ch. 5) embed the “jargon” of an interest or activity and connect them to tools (e.g., “hue”

and “layering” in image editing). New literacies invite participants to learn the “ways of speaking” within a domain of activity and help them to participate more fully within it in terms of knowing what to ask for, contributing knowledge and knowhow, and becoming more “expert.” Where they teach them at all, schools tend to teach premium grade traditional literacy (e.g., academic literacies of knowledge production in fields like science) in abstract ways, removed from specialist groups, mentors, and authentic practice.

- Playing with and exploring the affordances of a technology or online space balanced with serious work is a key element in learning to “be” someone, like a machinima artist, a games designer, a video editor, etc. (Ito et al., 2010). After the early grades, schools are concerned most with students being “on task” with little room for playful and exploratory experimentation.
- Working with multiple media types (podcasts, video, written texts, images, etc.) and across various online media spaces is common (Hayes & Duncan, 2012). Schools tend to have students work on separate things in one medium at a time.

Research findings are rarely final and conclusive. They are always provisional. We scrutinize them and ponder what their implications might be and how far we are prepared to use them as a basis for trying to develop alternatives to our current practices, or how much energy or risk we are prepared to invest by taking them seriously and acting upon them. In the final section we briefly outline some of the kinds of considerations these “lessons” or “findings” suggest to us. Readers will undoubtedly have their own ideas, thoughts, and evaluations. Meanwhile, we offer a sample of our own.

Implications for Teaching

There are any number of concrete implications for teachers and classrooms to be drawn from new literacies research findings about young people’s everyday practices, but three seem especially salient to us.

First, it is increasingly imperative for teachers *themselves* to experience and understand what it means to be fully engaged in new literacies practices. This is much more than simply reading about fan fiction, or watching a few anime music video clips, or

knowing that lots of kids read graphic novels. It requires commitment to getting to the “inside” of a practice and understanding what it means for something to be collaboratively produced, to be remixed, to receive feedback and mentoring from others, to participate in resourcing and sharing an interest or goal, to participate in a space where everyone doesn’t know exactly the same thing in the same way. Understanding the *ethos* of a new literacy means teachers can more readily see how to adapt and take up its socially important dimensions within the classroom, and minimize overly technicist, individuated, and curriculum-driven uses of literacy, digital technologies, and online spaces.

Second, new literacies aren’t some single, generic “thing.” They vary according to the practice, the people involved in using them, and the “ways of speaking” that have developed within a practice. Paying attention in classrooms to the specialized language used in new literacies affords students the chance to acquire what Gee and Hayes (2013; Gee, 2013) call “premium digital literacies.” Premium digital literacy competence flourishes in the world outside school where “young Pro-Ams” (professional amateurs) create “all sorts of media, citizen science, and knowledge in competition with experts via collaborative problem-solving communities on the Internet” (Gee, 2013, p. 60). Abstracting a new literacy from the language of its practice and replacing this language with classroom-specific ways of talking about it simply serves to replicate already existing divides between students who only have access to the kind of literacy instruction that prepares them for low-paying, low-status jobs, and students who have access to premium academic literacy that emphasizes the language of reasoning and argument and prepares them well for high-paying, high-status jobs (Gee, 2013).

Third, the way “assessment” works in new literacy spaces has significant implications for how teachers approach literacy instruction in classrooms. Increasingly, literacy teaching in school appears to be driven by required assessment outcomes rather than being in the service of learning. Findings from new literacies research suggest ongoing cycles of feedback on performance—just-in-time and just-in-place—lead to deep learning. Video game studies show how the game itself acts as a feedback system by providing guided tutorials, onscreen tips for increasing proficiency, and sequencing learning so that improvement is never far away (Gee, 2013; Hayes & Duncan, 2012).

Similarly, fan fiction studies show the central role reader reviews play in encouraging people to write more and to hone their narrative skills (Black, 2008; Curwood, Magnifico, & Lammers, 2013). Rethinking assessment practices and structuring learning experiences to include regular feedback on one or two elements of performance at a time, and/or that make space for regular and ongoing peer feedback and mentoring is a relatively do-able step for teachers wanting to make the most of new literacies in their classrooms.

Ultimately, a concern with “new literacies” is a concern with preparing students as best we can for a world in which there are few constants and the near future will involve artifacts, social relations, processes, routines, processes, and practices barely imaginable now. Studying new literacies offers useful footholds for thinking about how and why extant literacy practices are changing and new ones emerging in the present, why others are remaining constant, and what’s to be done about it.

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